IN 2019, India, the world's largest democracy, was ranked 27th in the Economist Intelligence Unit's annual Democracy Index. Now it is at the 46th position. Other global indices such as those of Freedom House and V-Dem Institute have also raised questions about democracy in India. In the latest INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation survey, too, respondents have expressed greater concern for the state of democracy than before—almost half feel that democracy is in danger today and only 37 per cent feel it is not in danger, the lowest level of confidence in 18 months.

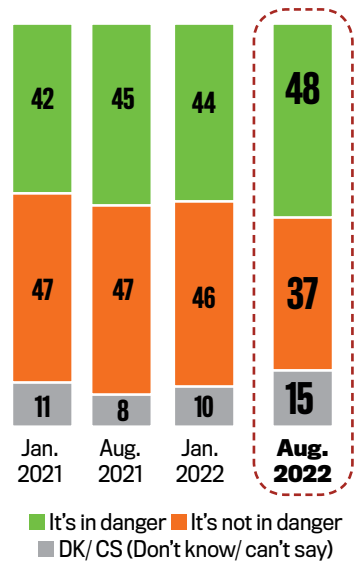
Suppression of citizens' voices is a threat to democracy, and much of the concern about Indian democracy stems from the growing number of criminal charges allegedly slapped on those who speak out against the ruling party. This year, the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data showed that 356 cases of sedition were filed and 548 people arrested under Section 124A (sedition) of the Indian Penal Code between 2015 and 2020. This prompted the Supreme Court to send out a powerful message, asking the central and state governments to refrain from filing FIRs and conducting proceedings in sedition cases. No wonder, a higher percentage of MOTN respondents (29) retain their faith in the judiciary to uphold democratic values, though it has fallen five percentage points from the previous MOTN poll.

Despite the growing concern about democracy, however, only 9 per cent respondents feel they cannot express an opinion on either religious or political matters. Almost half say they can freely express their opinions on either religion or politics, while 23 per cent say they can freely air their views on politics, but not on religion. Only 23.1 per cent, however, see social media networks as a good platform for speaking out, perhaps because several people have been arrested in recent years due to their posts on social media. A significant 42 per cent

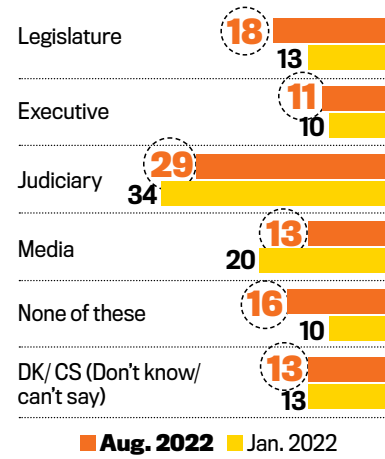


PREM SINGH/UNI

Q. What do you think of the current state of democracy in India?



Q. Which of the four pillars of democracy has best upheld democratic norms in India?



Graphics by **ASIT ROY**

(All figures in percentage)